

PHIL 101B: Introduction to Philosophy — Fall 2026

Instructor: Montague Reynolds, PhD | **Office:** Elizabeth Hall Rm. 104 | **Email:** mreynolds1@stetson.edu | **Phone:** 206-234-3477 | **Office Hours:** By appointment

Course Overview

Title: The Slow Existential Death of a Spaceman: Other Worldly Redemption, Virtual Love, and Real Sanctification

This course introduces undergraduates to philosophy using narrative thought experiments. We use David Chalmers' *Reality+: Virtual Worlds and the Problems of Philosophy* as our primary text, supplemented with classical philosophical works and contemporary readings.

Chalmers explores whether the simulation hypothesis—that we could be living inside a simulation—is viable, covering reasons for and against it across the philosophical discipline. The book examines how major philosophical figures might answer this hypothesis.

Core Thesis: Philosophy is rigorous thinking designed to cultivate intellectual virtue—suspending assumptions, asking fundamental questions, and wrestling with ideas abstractly and subjectively. Through game-based thought experiments, ideas reveal their real consequences for how we understand knowledge, reality, mind, and value, influencing how we act in the world.

Pedagogical Approach: You will do philosophy by: encountering philosophical thought experiments in narrative environments • designing game-based thought experiments • creating AI philosopher personas that ask Socratic questions • collaborating with peers in interactive gameplay • reflecting on how intuitions change through reasoning. You don't just understand the trolley problem abstractly; you participate in it. You don't just read about the experience machine; you explore it as an experience.

Learning Outcomes

By course end, you will be able to:

- Identify and articulate philosophical problems in classical and contemporary texts

- Recognize thought experiments as tools for philosophical reasoning and evaluate effectiveness
- Apply philosophical concepts (skepticism, realism, dualism, utilitarianism, etc.) to novel scenarios
- Design and create Socratic dialogue using AI philosopher personas
- Design game-based thought experiments that illuminate philosophical problems
- Reflect critically on your own intuitions and how reasoning changes them
- Collaborate effectively in philosophical discussions and creative game design
- Articulate philosophical positions clearly in writing and discussion

Required Materials

Primary Text: David Chalmers (2022). *Reality+: Virtual Worlds and the Problems of Philosophy*. W.W. Norton & Company. Core chapters: 1, 3, 4, 7, 8, 14, 15, 17, 18 (+ 4 additional TBD)

Secondary Readings: A.J. Ayer (1946). "The Elimination of Metaphysics" • Plato (various). Selected dialogues (provided via course management) • Additional readings assigned weekly

Technology & Platforms: Experience Machine (VR/Web-based philosophical environment) • Claude AI (Philosopher personas, web interface) • Game environment (Unity-based open-world simulator) • Course management: Canvas

Course Structure & Sections

Section	Days	Time	Location
01 (CRN 5322)	Mon, Wed	10:30–11:45 AM	duPont-Ball Library 25L
03 (CRN 5324)	Tue, Thu	10:00–11:15 AM	duPont-Ball Library 25L
04 (CRN 7912)	Tue, Thu	2:30–3:45 PM	duPont-Ball Library 25L

Enrollment: ~24–26 students per section

Assignment	Due Date	Points	% Grade
Weekly #1	Wed, Aug 29	20	6.3%
Weekly #2	Wed, Sept 12	20	6.3%
Persona #1	Fri, Sept 12	25	7.6%
Game Session 1 Reflection	Wed, Sept 19	15	4.6%
Weekly #3	Wed, Sept 26	20	6.3%
Weekly #4	Wed, Oct 3	20	6.3%
Weekly #5	Wed, Oct 10	20	6.3%
Persona #2	Fri, Oct 10	25	7.6%
Game Session 2 Reflection	Wed, Oct 17	15	4.6%
Weekly #6	Wed, Nov 7	20	6.3%
Persona #3	Fri, Nov 7	25	7.6%
Game Session 3 Reflection	Wed, Nov 14	15	4.6%
Final Project	Wed, Dec 11 (11:59 PM)	80	25%
Attendance		1	.6%
TOTAL		320	100%

Assignment Breakdown

Assignment	#	Points Each	Total	% Grade
Weekly	6	20	120	38%
Game Sessions	3	15	45	14%
Personas	3	25	75	23%

Assignment	#	Points Each	Total	% Grade
Final Project	1	80	80	25%
Attendance	1	1	6	.6%
TOTAL	—	—	320	100%

Attendance: You must be present in the class in order to submit your weekly. Therefore your weekly assignment grade is attached to your attendance grade.

Grade Scale: A 93–100% (297–320) | A- 90–92% (288–296) | B+ 87–89% (278–287) | B 83–86% (266–277) | B- 80–82% (256–265) | C+ 77–79% (246–255) | C 73–76% (234–245)

Final Thought

Philosophy begins with wonder. It's the practice of standing still, suspending what we think we know, and asking: "But what if I'm wrong? What does this really mean? Why does it matter?" In this course, we do that together—through reading, discussion, game-based thought experiments, and dialogue with philosophers past and present, who ask better questions than we ask ourselves. Welcome to philosophy. Let's think deeply about what matters.

See your section's detailed calendar for week-by-week topics, readings, and due dates.

Accessibility & Accommodations

If you anticipate barriers related to format or course requirements, meet with the instructor to ensure full participation. For disability-related accommodations, register with the Office of Academic Success, Accessibility Services Center, duPont-Ball Library 2nd floor (386-822-7127) and notify the instructor of your eligibility.

Honor System

Stetson University expects active student involvement and values honesty and integrity. Academic dishonesty rejects the academy's substance (learning and inquiry) and substitutes superficial externalities. Breaches rob both individual and institution.

The Honor Pledge: "If a student anticipates barriers related to the format or requirements of a course, they should meet with the course instructor to discuss ways to ensure full participation. If disability-related accommodations are necessary, students must register with the Office of Academic Success through the Accessibility Services Center located on the second floor of the duPont-Ball Library (386-822-7127) and notify the course instructor of their eligibility for reasonable accommodations."

All students subscribe to this pledge and reaffirm it by writing "pledged" before their signature on exams and papers. "As a member of Stetson University, I agree to uphold the highest standards of integrity in my academic work. I promise that I will neither give nor receive unauthorized aid on tests, papers, and assignments. When using ideas, thoughts, or words of another in my work, I will always provide clear acknowledgement of individuals and sources. I will avoid using fraudulent, falsified, or fabricated evidence/material. I will refrain from resubmitting without authorization work for one class previously submitted for academic credit in another. I will not destroy, steal, or make inaccessible any academic resource material. By my actions and example, I will strive to promote the ideals of honesty, responsibility, trust, fairness, and respect at the heart of Stetson's Honor System."

Generative AI Use

Students may use Generative AI for certain assignments. All AI-generated content must be clearly labeled and attributed to the AI source, with disclosure of the individual's role in curation/editing. Misrepresenting AI-generated content as original work or failing to attribute sources is a serious academic integrity violation. Discuss uncertainties with the instructor.

AI language models (e.g., ChatGPT) may be used for any assignment with appropriate citation (see General Citations - Guide to Writing at Stetson University – Guides at Stetson University). You are responsible for fact-checking AI-generated statements.

Title IX

Title IX of the Educational Amendments of 1972 prohibits sex discrimination in any federally-funded educational institution. Stetson does not tolerate sex/gender-based misconduct, discrimination, harassment, violence, intimate partner violence, or stalking. These may interfere with or limit ability to benefit from University programs.

Report incidents to: Executive Director & Title IX Coordinator (www.Stetson.edu/reportit or 386-822-7960) | Deputy Title IX Coordinator for Students (titleix@stetson.edu or 386-822-7205) | Public Safety (386-822-7300). **Confidential resources:** Student Counseling Services, Student

Health Service, or University Chaplain (Griffith Hall). Consult Stetson's Title IX Policy and Procedures for details.

Respect for Others

It is my intent that all students regardless of background and perspectives be well served by this course, that learning needs be addressed in and out of class, and that intrinsic value all students bring be viewed as resource, strength, and benefit. I will present materials and activities respectful of all persons. I appreciate your suggestions for improving effectiveness. Please let me know if class meetings conflict with religious events so we can arrange alternatives.

Campus Resources (FREE)

Hollis Family Student Success Center (Office of Academic Success): Study spaces (groups/individuals) • Success Coaches (time management, note-taking, test prep) • Tutoring • Writing Center • Stetson Peer Instruction (SPI) • Academic advising

Student Counseling Services Reasons to seek counseling: stress management, test anxiety, relationship concerns, trauma, adjustment to college, first time away from home

Services: Group sessions • Individual counseling • Confidential to enrolled students

Contact: 386-822-8900 | **Location:** Griffith Hall | **Hours:** Weekdays 8:00 AM–4:30 PM (closed 12:00–1:00 PM) | **Crisis (outside hours):** Mental health professional via WellConnect at 386-822-8900 #5

Staff: Qualified professional counselors trained to support students through difficult transitions, experiences, and feelings. Confidential and free for all enrolled students.

See also: Student grievance policies • Family Educational Rights Privacy Act • Other undergraduate student policies